

Beats Pill

Delivers the right dose of audio

₹16,900

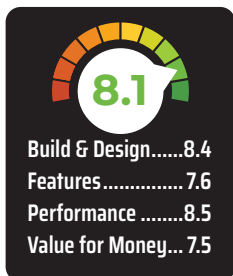


Beats by Dre audio products have officially

arrived in India. Starting September 4, Apple is making the Beats Solo 4, Beats Solo Buds, Beats Studio Pro, and the Beats Pill available through their website and retail stores, targeting the burgeoning Indian audio market. I got my hands on these devices and immediately kicked off my tests, starting with the Beats Pill portable speaker. The Beats Pill claims to be “Seriously Loud”, and it packs a host of premium features like IP67 dust and water resistance, lossless audio via a USB-C cable, Find My (Apple) and Find My Device (Android) support, Beats app support, and much more, in a portable and compact package. Priced at ₹16,900, it competes against formidable competitors like the JBL Flip 6 and Bose SoundLink Flex. Will it make its mark in the cutthroat Indian audio market? Here’s what I think:

BUILD AND DESIGN

Aptly named the Beats Pill, the speaker’s oblong pill-like design is eye-catching. Available in Champagne Gold, Statement Red, and Matte Black colours, even the most basic of the colours –



the Matte Black variant – looks striking. It features a metallic grille on the front and a matte silicone material wraps the rest of the speaker. The diminutive Beats logo sits in the centre of the metallic grille and looks discreet yet classy.

The speaker also comes with a removable lanyard on the right side; extremely convenient for outdoor use. Plus, the lanyard is colour-matched which is a nice little touch. The bottom of the speaker houses four small anti-slip feet, which provide excellent grip on most surfaces where the speaker is propped.

At the top, you’ll find the control panel, which includes the power button on the left and a status LED indicator beside it. There’s also a pinhole microphone for speakerphone calls. Next, you have the multifunction button, followed by dedicated volume buttons. Pressing the power button twice activates your phone’s voice assistant.

The controls are generally intuitive, although the power button was initially a bit confusing. You need to press and hold it for 2-5 seconds to turn the speaker on or off; holding it for longer doesn’t do anything, which is what I mistakenly did when I first used the speaker. The

buttons have indents, making them easy to locate in most situations, except in low-light conditions, where a backlight would have been a helpful addition.

The Beats Pill also impresses with an IP67 build, meaning it’s dustproof, and has water resistance of up to 1 meter for 30 minutes. The speaker isn’t buoyant though, so keep that in mind when you take it to your pool parties. At 680 g, the Pill is easily portable and is a great choice even when you’re doing outdoor activities or treks.

FEATURES

Priced at ₹16,900, the Beats Pill packs a fair number of features – it’s on par with similarly-priced portable speakers like the popular JBL Flip 6 and even the Sony SRS-XE300. One of my favourite features is the ability to play high-resolution, lossless audio by connecting the Beats Pill to your source device directly using a USB-C cable. It’s one of the few speakers on the market that supports USB playback. I also found that the low-end got a bit richer when playing music via USB-C. The Pill lacks auxiliary input though, which is a shame.

You can also use the USB-C port to charge other devices, like a pair of TWS earbuds or your phone! To reverse the charging direction, you will need to press the power button three times in quick succession.

The Beats Pill, being part of the Apple family, offers fast pairing with iOS devices and even includes ‘Find My’ support, which is a lifesaver if you ever misplace the speaker. Moreover, it integrates smoothly with the Android ecosystem, featuring Google Fast Pair and Find My Device support, allowing you to easily pair and locate the speaker across both platforms.

The Beats Pill gets its own dedicated section in iOS Settings, similar to AirPods, where you can adjust audio options, update firmware, and more. On Android, you can download the Beats app to access these same settings. However, I was disappointed with the app’s lack of essential features, such as EQ customisation.